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"My Precious"

As a member of the information age, you would probably agree with us when we say that our mobile phones hold just as much importance to us (if not more) as do our wallets or house keys. Walking around without that slight bulge in our pants paralyses us (figuratively of course) and renders us helpless. A mobile phone has become such an integral part of our daily lives that one would feel utterly abysmal should their prized possession get lost or worse still, stolen!

Find your missing partner

What about your precious data? What about all your hundreds of contacts... and of those precious hours you spent fiddling with your shiny new handset customising and personalising it to suit your needs and preferences!? Scary thought isn't it? Fret not my friend, help is on the way...

Oh crap! Someone please call my phone!

So let's assume that the worst has happened. Someone has made off with your

Siren!

Many applications we tested also come with a remote siren activation feature. So if you are in the vicinity of your phone, the loud noise emitted will lead you directly to the perpetrator's pocket!

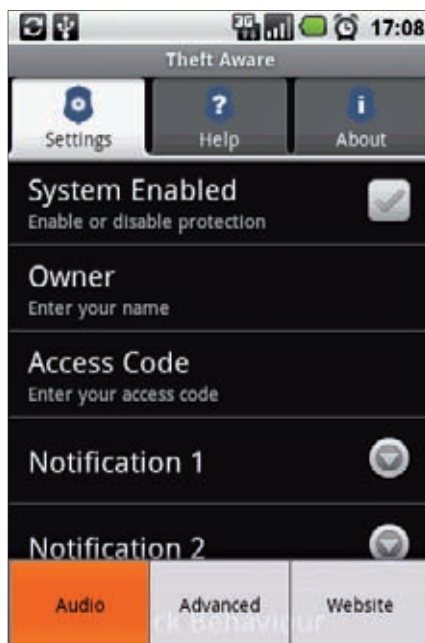
significant other. What now? File an FIR in the police, report it to your service provider yada yada...you know the drill. But you know what, if you are ignorant enough to think that your phone is going to be 'tracked' down using your 'IMEI number thingy', then you are highly mistaken my friend. You need to put yourself in the driver's seat and make sure that the perpetrator is caught. With the tools and

tips provided here, you would successfully be able to at least protect your valuable data if not recover your phone itself.

Hey buddy, that's MY phone

For those of you who prefer productivity on the go and choose to spend your hard earned moolah on a smartphone over a standard sub 7k phone, you must understand that with your 'smart'phone, comes the ability to install smart applications. Now unless the thief is intelligent enough to totally wipe the device and install a fresh operating system before even inserting a SIM card, you are protected. There are various means of tracking

Your definitive guide to mobile phone theft



Theft Aware on Android

down your device which you must leverage to your advantage. We tested various free and paid applications across all the popular platforms and have compiled our findings into a neat tabular column.

SMS: Most of these tracking appli-

Don't rely on IMEI!

The International Mobile Equipment Identity is no longer a reliable way of tracking your phone. Hacks have been developed which change the devices universal IMEI hence rendering that primitive way of tracking useless.

cations work on a system wherein you are required to set the application up with a 'buddy' telephone number of a friend/relative that you trust. The way in which this works is that the insertion of a new SIM other than yours will set off a trigger and inform your buddy number via SMS providing you the telephone number of the person currently in possession of your phone! This is a great option as you don't have to be bothered about whether or not the robber has got GPRS enabled on his SIM or not.

GPS & GPRS: Phones with an inbuilt GPS chip can use geographical information to inform your buddy of the current location of your phone in latitude and

Take photos of the thief!

Apple has recently applied for patents that will enable you to take a photo of the thief or record the voice of the thief currently in possession of your beloved Apple device. An existing implementation of something similar on Android exists on www.androidtheft.com. For now, iPhone users may enable a passcode from the general settings and also enable erase data which will delete all your data if there are 10 incorrect attempts.

longitude via SMS. There are alternatives which require the new SIM inserted to have GPRS enabled as well which is simply wishful thinking for us in India at this point in time. There are also existing services to remotely track your phone using a browser, but the down-